

(A Work in Progress)

An Account of The Lives of the Imperial Saints

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Volume One: On the Side of Heaven

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Part One: The Early Saints

These are the saints who ascended to Sainthood in the early years after the foundation of the church (Primus Deus Fidelis). The First Saint is generally regarded as having been Saint Avitus, whose real name has been lost in time, and who is now known only by his Imperial name. It is said "generally", since, some scholars and theologians maintain that his younger sister, Muriel, having died many decades prior, should rightfully be given the position of honour. However, most do agree that Avitus was the first mortal to transcend this world for the next, and that it was he who was invited to dwell, and later rule, in Heaven by the Angels. It is through his divine grace that all later saints ascended to their position.

Muriel, though, is regarded as the second saint, though her following has always been, and remains, quite small. Her name is known to most men and women, but few know that she does have active followers and several active convents.

Severinius (or Sever), controversially described as the true son of Avitus, is considered to be the father of the church, and the third saint. While Avitus gained his position through feats and deeds of extraordinary magnitude, across the mortal and immortal realms, Severinius is credited with the competent ruler-ship of his clan and setting down the rudimentary organisation and canons which would become the modern-day Primus Deus Fidelis.

Mairin was Severinius' guardian during his time hidden away in the Great Wood. Though she died of old age prior to the ascension of Avitus and the formation of the church, Severinius, upon his death and ascension to sainthood, it is said, took it upon himself to locate Mairin in the Valley of Death and lead her to Heaven, where he pled her case for admittance, and eventually for Sainthood. Today, Mairin's canon is one of the largest and most organised in the Empire, though it's largely domestic nature keeps it relatively innocuous.

The other 'Early Saints': Ida, Dunstan, Sebald, Ulric, Caspar, Caanan, and Judith are rough contemporaries of Severinius, and considered his primary disciples. It was these seven saints who are credited with much of the early work in the creation and establishment of the church. It is also rumoured that these seven assisted, in unknown, or unverifiable, ways, Severinius in writing the Canon of Saint Avitus.

1. Saint Avitus (real name unknown)

(Details of him to come later as his story forms the basis for most of what we're working on.)

2. Saint Severinius (real name is Sever)

Saint Severinius (Saint Sever) was the first Scion of Saint Avitus and is held by most to have been Saint Avitus' natural son. Having escaped murder at the hands of his uncle, Sever was spirited away from his village by an old seeress named Mairin. Saint Mairin raised Sever in the Great Wood until he was able to return to his village to assume the chieftainship of the tribe after his father's ascension (the story of Saint

Sever's youth is told in the epic poem "The Woodland King".) Saint Sever is attributed with the foundation of the Primus Deus Fidelis, as well as with the creation of the first Canon ("The Canon of Saint Avitus".) His coupling with the Angel named Ida resulted in the long line of the Vanderwail family, which has continued on to the present day, culminating with the present Scion, Sawl Avitus Vanderwail.

Severinius, today, continues to have one of the largest followings in the Empire. He is venerated by most common men, holding a special place among the administrators, magistrates and bureaucrats, and others of middling status. The Canon of Severinius continues to be supported by a large, and well organised number of missionaries, both clerical and lay, as well as a handful of monasteries and one knightly order.

The Prelate of Saint Severinius was the first to hand over his saint's canon and relics to the Scion, and remains, to this day, the staunchest ally of the Scion within the Conclave.

3. Saint Muriel

Saint Muriel was the sister of Saint Avitus. She was brutally raped and murdered by her eldest brother, the Lord of Hell. Her murder was initially attributed, wrongly, to Avitus, and it was for this crime that he was banished from his tribe. She died at the age of 12.

Muriel's following is small and almost exclusively female. She is seen as the protector of rape victims, victims of incest, and victims of similar abuse. She is also seen as the patron of children, especially those who've died prematurely; She is also seen as patron of all murder victims. Families of those who have been murdered, or those who have lost a child at a young age often pray to Muriel for her assistance in seeing them safe to the Judgement.

Muriel's Canon has no societies or knightly orders. However, there are known to be well over two dozen convents dedicated to Muriel. The largest, and wealthiest is located in the city of Lysander, although similar convents can be found within the cities of Avitus and Havilah, as well as in smaller cities and towns. By its very nature, the convents of Muriel are most often located in populated areas.

It is also rumoured that one of the convents of Saint Muriel is a training ground for a secret society of nuns who make it their life's mission to hunt down murderers, rapists, and those who have committed incest. It is said that these nuns, who have taken vows of chastity, poverty and obedience, are the most lethal assassins in the Empire, and that they operate with the blessing (and some say direction) of The Scion.

4. Saint Mairin

Saint Mairin is the maid and seeress who is credited with foreseeing the murder of Avitus' children, as well as the eventual rape and murder of Muriel. It is said that

she also saw the eventual outcome of the struggle between Avitus and his brother, and the foundation of the Primus Deus Fidelis. To this end, Mairin, a maid to Avitus and Ruth, switched her own baby with Sever on the day of the brutal murders. When the deed was done, and Mairin had fled into the Great Wood with the child Sever in her care, it was she that was blamed for the murder of the children of Avitus and Ruth. The tale of Mairin's abduction of Sever, and their wanderings in the Great Wood is told in the epic poem "The Woodland King", which forms the basis of both the Canon of Saint Mairin and the Canon of Saint Severinius.

Mairin's is a large and well organised Canon. Composed largely of countless monasteries and convents spread throughout the Empire and beyond, her followers are an optimistic and hard-working lot. She is viewed as a mother-figure by most common men, and is regarded as somewhat of a patron of agriculture, families, and children, as well as a patron by those who are wrongly persecuted and those who seek to hide from evil. But, perhaps most importantly, the nuns and monks of Mairin are sought after for their advice as prognosticators and diviners.

5. Ida

Not really a Saint, though worshipped as such. Regardless, Ida was the messenger angel that Avitus dispatched from Heaven to Earth to relate his tale to his son Severinius. Condemned to die on Earth as a result of her mission, Ida fell in love with Severinius (or so it is said. Some scholars maintain that her marriage to Severinius was part of her mission) and eventually married him, and bore him several children.

The worship of Ida has mostly fallen out of fashion, and is all but unknown outside the older areas of the Empire. Her soul was destroyed as a result of her exile and death on Earth, so she does not exist to be able to grant spells or powers. Still a cult or two in her name persists.

Ida's name is most commonly uttered in association with those who ply the world's oldest profession. The belief that Ida might have only borne Severinius children out of an obligation to Avitus is one that has taken root in the popular culture to an extent. In this fashion, Ida is often cited as patron of prostitutes.

6. Saint Dunstan

Dunstan was the eldest of Severinius' two sons by Ida. He was an Angelspawn and a fierce warrior by all accounts, as well as a skilled craftsman with both iron and wood, Dunstan never succeeded his father in the leadership of the tribe. That honour fell to his younger brother, Sebald. For his part, Dunstan was the tribal champion and blacksmith, as well as a gifted carver and carpenter. The feats of combat prowess, the tales of battles and of physical tests found within his canon are many. As are the tales and legends of the dozens upon dozens of magical items, relics and artefacts he is said to have created.

Dunstan is seen as a patron of craftsmen, athletes, hard work, and soldiers. His is a crusading and missionary sect, often successfully combining technical innovation with proven tactical methods. Saint Dunstan boasts of a fairly large number of

monasteries, clerical societies, and knightly orders, and has a well organised, devout and wealthy following.

Dunstan's followers are unique in the faith in that they have often fully supported the advancement and procurement of knowledge. His monasteries have, in the past, served as scriptoriums and laboratories, as well as workshops and factories for the creation of all manner of tools, weapons and implements. Dunstan's monks are credited (though with some heavy doubts by some scholars) with the invention of gunpowder, among other things.

Unlike most other crusading canons, Dunstan's knights take full advantage of the technological and scientific advances and advantages available in our modern era. While a knight of Saint Avitus might still take to the field mounted and in full armour at the head of a cavalry charge, Dunstan's crusaders are more often found sensibly dressed and armed with firearms and light weapons. Although, the true value of Dunstan's knight in the modern day lies not with his prowess with a blade or even with his accuracy with a musket, but, rather, in his skill with artillery of all types.

Despite the mostly military nature of Dunstan's canon, he is still a patron of innovation. For this, his followers are always very well regarded and received in most of the world's institutions of learning. However, it was for this reason that Saint Dunstan's canon suffered the heaviest during The Cleansing.

7. Saint Sebald

Sebald was the youngest of Severinius and Ida's two sons. Like Dunstan, he was a half-man, half-angel Celestials spawn. Upon the death of Severinius, he was acclaimed chieftain of the clan and proclaimed the second Scion of Saint Avitus. Under Sebald's long ruler-ship, the ideas behind the Primus Deus Fidelis as they relate to the relationship of Heaven and Hell began to take shape. Many scholars proclaim Sebald to be the true originator of the religion. While Severinius might have received the word from his father by way of Ida, and then enshrined it in the mysterious Canon of Saint Avitus, it is Sebald who really gave birth to the idea of a new way of thinking about man's relationship with death and the afterlife. With his warrior brother, Dunstan, at his side, Sebald is also credited with being the proper founder of the Empire as he sought to conquer and assimilate the neighbouring villages, clans and tribes.

Most historians also believe that Sebald chose the site for the current castle, and residence of the Scions, known as The Valdenwail, and that he erected the first permanent structure on that site.

Sebald's is an odd canon. He is considered more of a historical, or political, figure, rather than a religious one, and seems to have obtained his sainthood only by dint of heredity and not through any special deeds or merit. Indeed, it is this fact which is often referred to as the true origin of the tradition of a hereditary Scion as head of the church and of the Empire.

He is possessed of no true organised followers in modern times, though he is still seen as a patron of the nobility and of the right of inheritance. There are no

organised monasteries of Sebald, though there are a few societies and knightly orders in his honour. However, these are more akin to exclusive clubs restricted to only those of noble birth and those possessing celestial blood, than they are to true religious orders.

8. Saint Ulric

Ulric was a warrior, and friend of Dunstan's. It was said that the two would often compete against one another in tests of physical strength, agility and endurance to determine who was the best warrior in the clan. There are several stories in the canons of both saints regarding their trials and contests, but it has never been made clear or confirmed which of the two men, if either, was ever determined to be the winner. However, that Ulric was entirely human and Dunstan was a half-angel speaks quite highly of Ulric's abilities.

Ulric holds the distinction, aside from Saint Mairin, of being the first saint elevated to that status without being a blood relative of Saint Avitus. Indeed, since it is difficult to measure relative time in the Valley of Death, it is unclear whether Saint Ulric ascended to Sainthood before Severinius found Mairin in the Valley, and brought her to Heaven. Regardless, Ulric was awarded his position in heaven as a result of a long series of heroic and legendary deeds.

While Dunstan is the patron of soldiers and warfare, Ulric is the patron of the hero. While the military canon of Dunstan stresses the importance of the organised and well led combat unit, the canon of Ulric stresses the importance of personal heroics and bravery. For this reason, Ulric's followers range the gamut from chivalrous knights, to villainous mercenaries out for personal glory. The canon of Saint Ulric has room enough for both, and many in between, as the important thing is the fulfilment and pursuit of personal ambition.

Ulric has many knightly orders and clerical societies, but it lacks in any significant monastic strength. The inherent nature of his canon is often at odds with the more monastic virtues. However, some knightly orders are organised along lines similar to those of monasteries.

It is difficult to find a more stereotypical figure within the Empire than a Knight of Saint Ulric. The typical crusaders, questing knights and errant warriors, Ulric's loyal followers can be found in volume throughout the pages of history and of legend. However, in modern times, this stereotype no longer fits exactly. To be sure, Ulric's followers still contain enough heavily armoured and mounted knights to continue pursuing several crusades. However, the more modern face of Ulric's worship can be found in the young men that populate the many trading and merchant houses in the cities of the Empire. To these young men, Ulric is the patron of ambition and victory. The object of the quest may have changed, but the rules remain mostly the same. While a few centuries ago they might have taken up sword and shield to seek personal glory on the battlefield, this young breed of Saint Ulric's now take up ledgers and scales and seek their glory (and fortunes) on the battlefields of commerce, trade and finance. As a result, Ulric is now also viewed as the patron of these endeavours.

9. Caspar (Saint/Hellion)

Saint Caspar was another of Severinius' early disciples, and a contemporary of Sebald, Dunstan and Ulric. It is well known and established that he was the tribe's priest in the practice of its barbaric pagan rituals. For most of his life he opposed the teachings of Severinius and Sebald, and vehemently cursed all who had abandoned the heresy he preached in favour of the saintly faith. Caspar remains an enigma, in that it is maintained that he never truly accepted the Saintly faith within his lifetime, and died a fierce opponent of it. However, his canon teaches that it was his doubts and oppositions, and his strongly held convictions that prompted Saint Avitus to elevate this man to sainthood nonetheless. The canon teaches that it takes formidable strength of character to take a stand based upon one's convictions in face of overwhelming opposition.

Caspar, due to his origins, is a confusing figure. He is considered to be the patron of martyrs by some, and patron of fools by others. He is said to be the one responsible for allowing men to continue to question and doubt all new theories and ideas, but he is also said to be the patron of the ignorant. Alas, the canon of Caspar is a confusing one.

Composed mainly of hermit monks in the most remote reaches of the empire, they are said to care little for the fate of men or of the church these days. Some consider Caspar to be a Hellion, rather than a Saint. Or perhaps a corrupted saint. Certainly there is little doubt in the part that the Casparians played during The Cleansing. Few common men would consider Caspar a Heavenly Saint, though, reluctantly, most scholars still attribute this position to him. Regardless, since his following is made up of only a small number of hermit monks, few really care about his fate.

As a historical note, it is of great importance to note that Caspar's monks were primarily, and in the view of the current Scion, solely, responsible for the events known as The Cleansing. At the time, the followers of Caspar were many, and they preached against the proliferation of knowledge and the expansion of science. The Casparians sought to bring the empire back to its roots as a tribal society, and re-establish the rule of religion that Saint Caspar is said to have practised before Saint Avitus. Of course, while this did not come to pass, it is not easy to dismiss the bloodshed and war that was caused by them. But the story of The Cleansing is one best told in its proper place.

Today, Caspar's name is most often mentioned as a curse or as an insult. Foolishness, stubbornness, and the reluctance to accept change are all traits that are often cursed at with Caspar's name.

10. Caanan (Saint/Hellion)

Little is known of Saint Caanan. Indeed, he is often referred to by scholars as "The Forgotten Saint". What is known of Caanan is this: he was a contemporary of Severinius and a member of his tribe; and his name is still freely invoked by the

common man whenever and wherever misfortune strikes.

No known followers of Caanan are known to exist, but, given the mysterious nature of this saint, it is doubtful that any true followers of Caanan would identify themselves as such.

Because of his loose association with Severinius, and the fact that mention is made within Severinius's Canon of the existence of a "Canon of Saint Caanan", he is often labelled as a saint by scholars. However, given his deep associations with misfortune and catastrophe, it is little wonder that most would consider him a Hellion.

11. Saint Judith

A major saint, Judith was the wife of Saint Sebald, and, it is said, gained her status simply as a result of her relationship to him. Whatever modern theology ascribes for the reason behind her ascension, her canon teaches that Judith was very competent, in life, with all aspects of agricultural endeavours. With her husband's establishment of The Valdenwail as a permanent settlement, it is strongly believed (or suggested) that Judith was instrumental in the early attempts at establishing permanent farms and ranches in the area surrounding the Valdenwail, and what is now the city of Avitus.

As such, Judith is primarily worshipped by farmers, ranchers, and those heavily involved in or dependent on agriculture. This nature also extends to patronage of the weather, resulting in her name being blessed or cursed depending on the meteorological conditions of the day. Where Mairin is viewed as a patron of agriculture in the sense that cultivation furthers life and growth, Judith is viewed as a patron of agriculture where cultivation represents the triumph of man over nature.

Saint Judith is also considered the patron of women in their role as women. That is, she does not represent women as victims (Muriel), mothers (Mairin), prostitutes (Ida) or in any form other than as women themselves.

Further, Saint Judith is also patron of all who breed animals.

Judith's following is strong, well-organised and highly independent. It is an almost exclusively rural following, with only token worship found within urban centres. Most of Judith's followers are found within societies and churches, not monasteries or knightly orders (indeed, there are no knightly orders to Saint Judith, though, horses bred by the clerics of Judith have long been the mount of choice for all knights of the Empire.) A few monasteries and convents to Judith do exist, however, these usually take the form of organised farms or ranches rather than cloistered abbeys. The bulk of the canon's organisation is found in its clerical societies and parish churches.

As a brief aside, the one notable institution belonging to the worship of Saint Judith within the city of Avitus is the Society of Erasmus, the leading kennel and animal husbandry club in the Empire. Erasmus, it is said, was a favourite horse of a long-ago Scion, which was bred specifically for him as a coronation gift by the clerics

of Saint Judith. Erasmus was considered to be the pinnacle of the breed, and indeed, it is said that no horse has ever quite matched Erasmus in quality and breeding. The Society of Erasmus, housed in a small building near Lord's University in Avitus, and staffed by a few of the faithful of Saint Judith, is charged with maintaining a detailed record of the accepted and acknowledged breeds of domesticated animals within the empire, as well as a record of bloodlines and lineages of various champion specimens from the different animal varieties. It is said that foolish is he who does not pay the nuns of Erasmus a visit before placing a bet on a particular racehorse.

To be Continued